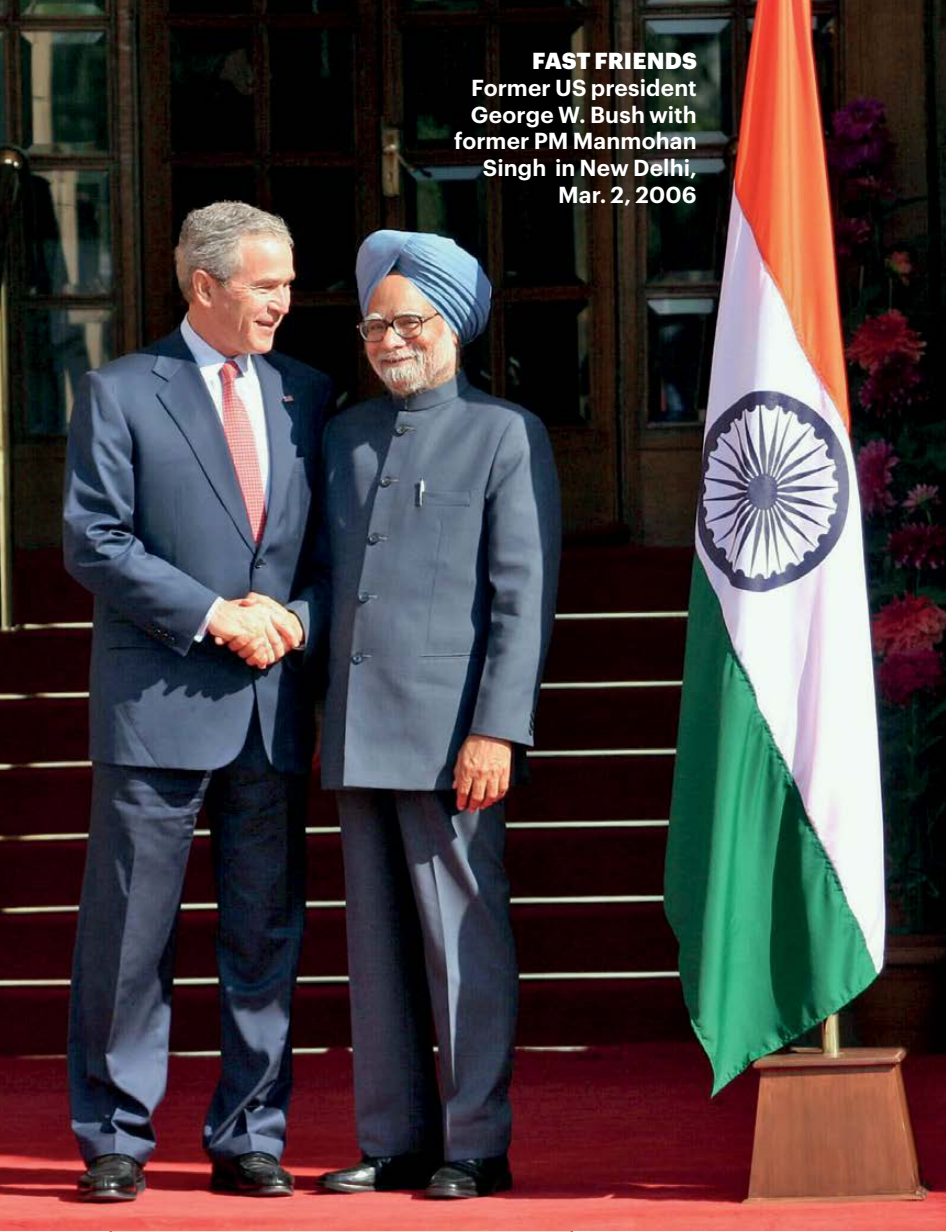
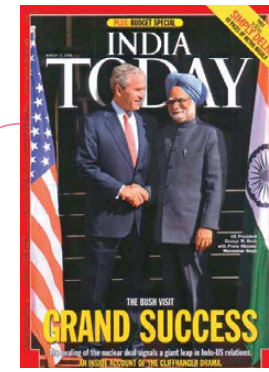


FAST FRIENDS
Former US president George W. Bush with former PM Manmohan Singh in New Delhi, Mar. 2, 2006

HEMANT CHAWLA



FROM THE ARCHIVES
March 13, 2006

Cover Story
The Giant Leap

After his (George W. Bush) arrival, the two teams worked through the night to sort out the differences. One of the major hurdles was as one negotiator described it: "The ghost of Tarapur stalking the room." Tarapur was a reactor built with US collaboration in 1969 with an agreement that it would have assured fuel supply. But after the 1974 nuclear test, the US initially denied it to India and then made it sweat every time it ran out of fuel. The US has put into the current deal several insurances that would prevent such a recurrence.

-Raj Chengappa

A MIXED BAG

- **The deal was foundational to the close strategic ties India shares with the US**
- **It ended India's nuclear isolation, enabling it to sign deals for import of Uranium from Russia, Australia, France, Canada**
- **It enabled India to continue to develop nuclear weapons and permitted weapons grade reactors to be out of the ambit of the IAEA**
- **The nuclear agreement faced political resistance in India, with concerns about compromising strategic autonomy to US influence**

the Nuclear Suppliers Group to allow it to engage in civilian nuclear trade despite being a non-signatory to the NPT. Thirdly, the agreement enabled India to import nuclear reactors, technology, and uranium from the US and other countries. Although the deal did not explicitly prohibit India from conducting future nuclear tests, doing so could terminate the agreement. In a broader sense, the pact signalled India's arrival as a key player in the global order. While critics argued that the deal undermined the NPT by making an exception for India, proponents highlighted India's strong non-proliferation record.

The deal's significance lies in its enduring impact on India's strategic partnerships, energy security and global standing. It serves as a template for how nations can reconcile differing priorities to achieve mutual gains. Moreover, the deal symbolised a shift in US foreign policy, recognising India as a responsible nuclear power and a key partner in Asia.

The deal encouraged India to invest in nuclear infrastructure and helped it to frame a roadmap, with the aim to produce 63 GW of nuclear energy by 2032. India's burgeoning energy needs make nuclear power a crucial component of its energy mix that would reduce dependence on coal and oil, thus aligning with global efforts to combat climate change. The agreement reinforced India's commitment to peaceful nuclear energy and global security norms. ■